Car Emergency Kit Checklist

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/car-emergency-kit/, which lists its sources. Updated November 5, 2026.

The car emergency kit checklist

Adapted from NHTSA's and Ready.gov's lists. Pack them in a bag or bin that stays in the trunk.

SAFETY AND REPAIR

- [ ] Jumper cables
  Cold weather drains batteries. In the cold, engines need more battery power to start.
- [ ] Flashlight, plus extra batteries
- [ ] Flares, reflective triangles or other emergency markers
- [ ] A whistle, to signal for help
- [ ] A paper map of the area
  Phones die and lose signal.

FIRST AID AND COMFORT

- [ ] A first-aid kit, including a tourniquet
  NHTSA's list includes a tourniquet. Learn to use one in a Stop the Bleed® class.
- [ ] Any medicines you or your passengers need
- [ ] Bottled water
- [ ] Non-perishable snacks
- [ ] A blanket
- [ ] A phone and a car charger

WINTER ADD-ONS

- [ ] A snow shovel, broom and ice scraper

- [ ] Sand or kitty litter
  Pour it under the tires for traction if you get stuck.
- [ ] Extra blankets and warm clothes: hats, gloves and dry socks
- [ ] Winter washer fluid with de-icer, with the reservoir full
  One snowstorm can use a lot of it.

Keep the gas tank close to full whenever you can, or an electric car charged. A full tank helps in an evacuation or a power outage, and it keeps the fuel line from freezing.

Check the car before winter

Tire pressure
Pressure drops as it gets colder. Inflate to the number on the label in the driver's door frame, not the maximum printed on the tire, and check when the tires haven't been driven for at least 3 hours.

Tread
At least 2/32 of an inch. Put a penny in the tread with Lincoln's head upside down: if you can see the top of his head, replace the tire. Consider winter tires, or chains or studs where they're required.

Battery
Have a mechanic check the battery, charging system and belts. Electric and hybrid cars lose range in the cold.

Lights and wipers
Check headlights, brake lights, turn signals and flashers. Test the defroster and replace worn wiper blades.

Coolant
Enough coolant (antifreeze) that meets your owner's manual, with no leaks.

Recalls

Look up your vehicle on NHTSA's recall lookup. Recall repairs are free.

If you're stranded

1. **Call 911** if you're in danger or someone is hurt.
2. **Stay in the car.** It's your shelter. Don't wear yourself out.
3. **Make the car visible.** Put something bright on the antenna or in a window, and keep the dome light on.
4. **Prevent carbon monoxide poisoning.** Clear snow from the exhaust pipe, and run the engine only now and then, just long enough to stay warm. Don't run it for long with the windows up or in an enclosed space.
5. **Stay warm.** Use the blankets and warm clothes in your kit.

Tick items off on your iPhone. BugOut, the free offline survival app, lets you make your own checklists and keeps its guides on your phone with no signal.